Prepared From Path Lesson

School: Xplore Evidence School

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Hook the learner with the sunflower mystery and recall that animals eat but plants do not.

Animals get their food by eating other living things—like a rabbit eating grass or a hawk eating a mouse. But plants don't eat anything. They stay rooted in one place, yet they grow tall, produce flowers, and make seeds. Think back to what you learned about plant parts and what plants need. How do you think a plant gets its food to grow and stay healthy?

Turn and talk with a partner. Share any ideas or things you remember about how plants get what they need. Maybe you've noticed something about their leaves, stems, or roots. We'll gather our thoughts together before we explore this mystery further.

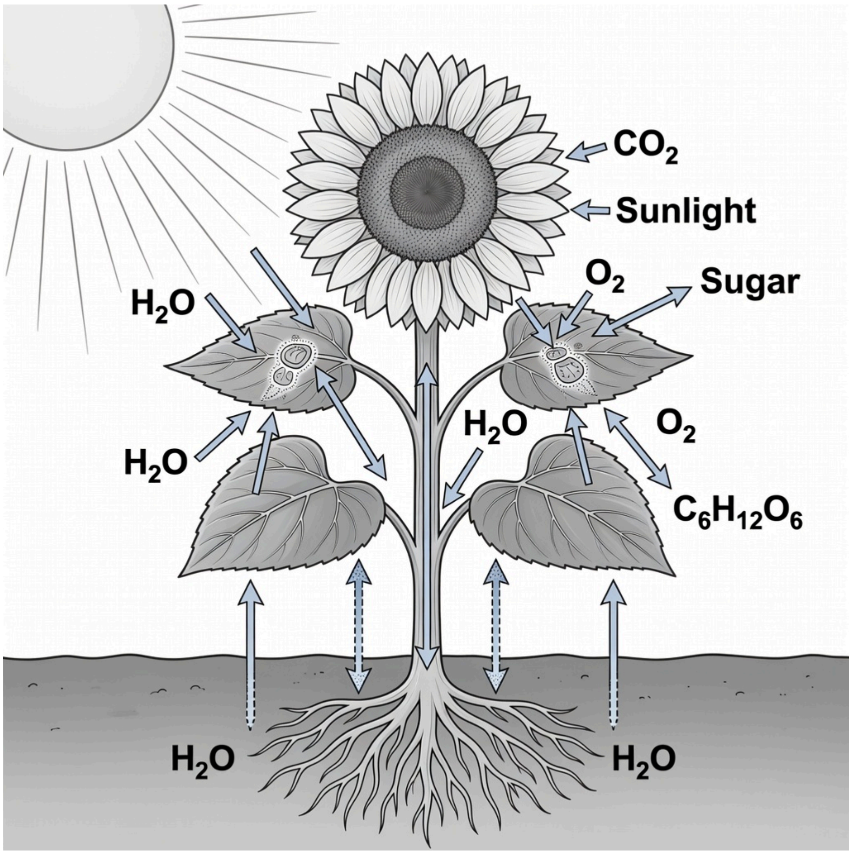
Imagine a tall, bright sunflower standing in a sunny field. Day after day, it grows taller and pushes its golden petals toward the sky. Nearby, a rabbit nibbles grass and a bird pecks at seeds—animals need to eat to get the energy to grow. But this sunflower never takes a bite, never chews, never hunts. It just stands in the soil under the sun.

So here is the puzzle: How does this sunflower get its food if it never eats anything? Think about what you already know about plants. What ideas do you have? We won't solve this mystery just yet—let the question hang in the air.

Build the idea of a producer and photosynthesis through the sunflower example.

In nature, living things need food for energy. Some living things, like animals, have to eat other living things. But plants are different. A living thing that can make its own food is called a producer. The sunflower in our sunny field is a producer. It does not eat worms or grass like a bird might. Instead, it makes the food it needs right inside its own body.

The way a sunflower makes its food is called photosynthesis. Photosynthesis means 'making food using light.' Inside the sunflower's leaves, there is a green substance called chlorophyll. Chlorophyll helps the plant catch energy from sunlight. The plant then uses this light energy to turn simple ingredients into sugar, which is the plant's food. So, the sunflower makes its own food using light—no eating required!



Sunlight, water, and carbon dioxide make sugar and oxygen.

A sunflower is a producer: it makes its own food from these inputs and outputs.

Input: carbon dioxide from the air.

Input: water from the roots.

Input: light from the Sun.

Output: sugar – the plant's food.

Output: oxygen – a gas released.

Show the boundary between producers and consumers, and surface the soil-food misconception.

Sunflower vs. Rabbit: Which Is a Producer?

QUESTION	SUNFLOWER	RABBIT
How does it get food?	Makes its own food inside itself.	Eats grass, another living thing.
What is this way of getting food called?	Photosynthesis	Eating

QUESTION	SUNFLOWER	RABBIT
Does it eat other living things?	No.	Yes.
Is it a producer?	Yes, because it makes its own food.	No, because it eats other living things.

A bean plant grows in a jar of water containing dissolved minerals. There is no soil. How does this plant get its food?

a. It absorbs food from the water through its roots.

b. It uses sunlight directly as its energy, so it does not need food.

c. It makes its own food using water, minerals, and energy from sunlight.

d. It does not need food because it lives in water.

Check whether learners can recognise the defining feature of a producer.

A cow eats grass. Which statement correctly compares how the cow and the grass get their food?

a. The cow eats other things; the grass absorbs its food from the soil.

b. The cow eats other things; the grass uses sunlight directly for energy, not food.

c. The cow is a consumer that eats other living things; the grass is a producer that makes its own food.

d. The cow is a producer because it makes milk; the grass is a consumer because it uses sunlight.